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SUKASH CHANDRASHEKAR
Conman

In the last 15 years, Sukash has allegedly defrauded a thousand people of at least ₹500 crore

MASTER SWINDLER

In 2022, investigators turned the spotlight on India's most notorious conman who duped several top people

By Kaushik Deka

He is perhaps the most notorious conman of independent India whose alleged mass skullduggery came to light this year. Sukash Chandrashekar has fooled nearly a thousand people in the last 15 years to swindle, at least, Rs 500 crore. This is based on more than 30 cases lodged in six states—Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Maharashtra and Delhi. His biggest heist came between June 2020 and May 2021 when, sitting inside Delhi's Rohini jail, he conned the wife of a jailed industrialist, making her pay up over Rs 200 crore. The modus operandi was his tried-and-tested trick—impersonate, over the phone, a senior government official and ask for money in return for a favour. This time, as Union law secretary, he promised bail for the woman's jailed husband.

While investigating the case this year, the police stumbled on his other passion—showering gifts on female film actors. As per an Enforcement Directorate chargesheet, the Bengaluru-born conman spent more than Rs 7 crore between February and August 2021 on gifts meant for actor Jacqueline Fernandez and her family. Sukash says they were in love, but the actor has denied the claim.

Around the same time, he unsuccessfully tried to woo four other female actors using his weapon of mass deception: the mobile phone. Police officers, who have dealt with him, add two more skillsets: the art of glib talk and command of multiple languages, including English, Hindi, Tamil, Kannada, Telugu and Malayalam.

Sukash's charm and money power helped him live like a king inside the Rohini jail. He was allotted an entire barrack, and enjoyed several luxuries, including having his own BMW car to ferry his occasional guests. He had amenities like a smartphone, television and air-conditioner while other inmates washed his clothes and utensils. These facilities came at a price of around Rs 60-75 lakh every fortnight, states the Delhi Police chargesheet. And if Sukash is to be believed, it's not just the jail officials whom he bribed. Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal and his cabinet colleague Satyendar Jain too have been mentioned as beneficiaries in the conman's letters to Delhi's lieutenant governor. The charges, however, have been denied.

As Sukash now awaits a long trial, he has declared himself innocent. Not surprising—he has not been convicted in a single case till today. ■